

~~CONFIDENTIAL~~

NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20504

7820

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Meeting with Presidents Alija Izetbegovic of the Republic of Bosnia-Herzegovina and Franjo Tudjman of the Republic of Croatia

PARTICIPANTS: U.S.
The President
Warren Christopher, Secretary of State
Madeleine Albright, U.S. Permanent Representative to the United Nations
Anthony Lake, Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs
Richard Holbrooke, Assistant Secretary of State for European and Canadian Affairs
Alexander Vershbow, Special Assistant to the President and Senior Director for European Affairs, NSC (Notetaker)

Bosnia-Herzegovina
President Alija Izetbegovic
Muhammed Sacirbey, Foreign Minister
Nedzib Sacirbey, Ambassador-at-large
Mr. Ivan Misic, Ambassador to the UN
Mr. Bakir Sadovic, President's Private Secretary
Mr. Amela Sapcanin, Second Secretary

Croatia
President Franjo Tudjman
Mate Granic, Deputy Foreign Minister
Miomir Zuzul, Special Envoy
Petar Sarcevic, Ambassador to the U.S.
Zeljko Matic

DATE, TIME October 24, 1995 1:35 - 2:15PM
AND PLACE: Waldorf Astoria Hotel
New York, New York

The President: First, let me say how pleased I am to have all of you together in one room, especially the two presidents. Let me add how profoundly appreciative I am that you are going to Dayton in a few days to take part in the proximity talks. We need to do everything we can to make these talks a success. It is important not to take any positions or say anything that would short-

~~CONFIDENTIAL~~

Classified by: Andrew Sens

Reason: 1.5(h), (g)

Declassify on: 10/27/05

DECLASSIFIED
PER E.O. 13526

CLINTON LIBRARY PHOTOCOPY

circuit the talks before they even begin. We are committed to an honorable resolution that will preserve the integrity of Bosnia, which would protect the rights of all of its citizens, and which would support the Federation. I want to do everything I can to ensure success, but I urge you to create the proper atmosphere that will produce a success in Dayton. ~~(C)~~

We have seen things in the last few years that we never expected to see: Israel and the PLO sitting down after 30 years of fighting; the IRA laying down its arms, at least for a year, after 25 years of guerrilla warfare and terrorism. But what the world wants more than anything else is for a resolution of the war in Bosnia. Only you can provide it, and President Milosevic has responsibilities as well. If an agreement is made, I will ensure that a strong, disciplined and coordinated force is there to implement it. The United States will play a major role, and we will also work aggressively to rebuild war-torn areas and to open up economic opportunities for both your countries. The Europeans will take the lead on the economic side, but we will do our share and then some. So we are at a hopeful, positive moment, yet we are also aware of the dire consequences if we fail. ~~(C)~~

The only other statement that I wanted to make is that you did a great thing when you created the Federation. It has changed the military situation. The significant strengthening of the Croatian and Bosnian armies has helped make a decent peace possible. Without that I am not sure that the NATO bombing or Dick Holbrooke's diplomacy would have worked; the differences might have still been too great. I have nothing but admiration, but you both must work hard to make the Federation a reality on the ground. There are still many tensions and problems, and we should not let the Serbs or any other adversaries exploit your differences. Only you can help. You need to strengthen the Federation in the lives, minds and hearts of your people. They are the ones who need to make it work. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: Thank you for receiving us. We have great expectations for the peace negotiations. We are entering the talks with the best of will. Our people want peace. The war has gone on for 44 months, which is much too long. You should believe in our sincerity; we want peace. We are afraid that the position of the Serb side is still very far from ours in the negotiations. I could summarize by saying that we want to preserve an integral Bosnia and we want to discuss common institutions and functions. We ask for your support in accomplishing this during the negotiations. The American side has made very positive statements and now we need to convince the Serbs to accept. In sum, the question of constitutional principles is more important for us than the map. I feel that it

is essential that we have a constitutional solution that preserves Bosnia-Herzegovina. Without this, we cannot have peace. ~~(C)~~

Regarding the Federation, all the parties present here support the Federation in words. No one is against it, but on the ground, the process of implementation has not taken place as it should have. We cannot even speak of freedom of movement in some areas. Mostar is a special problem. The return of refugees is another. Of course the Croatian side has its own view of these problems and President Tudjman will give you his perspective. We are asking for total freedom of movement. We want refugees to be able to return, especially to areas that have recently been freed, where there are empty houses. But they are being prevented from returning. The case in point is Jajce, a city that was half and half, Croatian and Muslim, before the war. Jajce was liberated by the Croatian side and the Croatian population has returned, but the Bosniac people have not been permitted to come back. This is absurd. Fifteen to twenty days ago we supervised the return of Croatian people to their land in the town of Bugojno. We have received a positive response from the Croatian side in Bugojno, but when the Bosniac people want to return, the Croatian side has rejected this right. ~~(C)~~

Yesterday and today, we had talks in Madrid among the Friends of the Federation. The U.S. Representative proposed two papers regarding Mostar and the Federation as a whole. I am ready to sign them regardless of what the papers say, because they were proposed by a third party. The EU has also written a paper and I am prepared to sign that. I hope the Croatian side will also accept these papers. The EU is prepared to do positive things for both sides and it could help solve all of our problems very quickly. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: Thank you Mr. President for seeing us and thank you for the role that the U.S. and you personally have played in order to achieve peace in the former Yugoslavia. I also want to thank Richard Holbrooke for his enormous efforts, including his physical efforts, that have made the meeting in Ohio possible. I would like to explain not only what we hope to achieve but what is necessary for peace. Ohio should not just be a step forward, but a solution to the conflict. I certainly welcome the idea of having the representatives of the three countries meeting until peace is achieved. But if the talks fail, taking into account the experience of this conflict and of earlier history, I would suggest that the United States and the international community impose a peace on those who are not willing to accept it. I think that the idea of involving NATO and U.S. forces can be achieved. Once we have a real agreement, I don't think anyone can oppose NATO's role in enforcing it.

This would represent a way out of the problem, a way out of a catastrophic situation, and NATO would be necessary to creating a new international order in our part of the world. ~~(C)~~

Mr. President I have told your representatives a number of times that along with the Bosnian issue, the agenda in Ohio also needs to address the reintegration of Eastern Slavonia, the last Serb-occupied area of Croatia. Although Croatian public opinion is bitter over the delay in solving this issue -- and there are still 125,000 displaced persons from Eastern Slavonia -- I have made a commitment not to interfere with the peace process, and not to take any other step while the peace talks are underway and before the UNCRO mandate expires. It is with pleasure that I would like to praise the involvement of the U.S. Ambassador to Croatia in the negotiations between the government of Croatia and the local Serbs. There was a meeting yesterday and talks will continue later in the week. These talks provide grounds for optimism that a peaceful solution can be achieved. But if these talks fail, then the issue of Eastern Slavonia should be included in the Ohio talks. ~~(C)~~

As for the Federation, let me remind everyone of your role and that of your government in establishing the Federation. We can be satisfied with the results so far. We have stopped the hostilities to a degree greater than one sees in the Middle East and Northern Ireland. I don't want to go into the details that President Izetbegovic has raised regarding problems in implementing the Federation Agreements. But I believe that first and foremost, this is a problem for the Muslim and Croat leaders within Bosnia. In this regard, it is surprising that there are no Bosnian Croat representatives here. Croatia, for strategic reasons and as a friend of Europe and the United States, will do everything to implement the Federation in deeds as well as in words. ~~(C)~~

The President: I appreciate what you have said about Eastern Slavonia. I agree that the issue should be resolved in the peace talks. It is very important that you have agreed to exercise restraint while the peace talks are taking place. With respect to the disputes within the Federation and relations between the Bosnians and the Bosnian Croats, this just illustrates my point. We need more personal contacts between your representatives in order to make the Federation work on the ground. Getting a settlement will depend on the two of you having trust. Strength lies in genuine unity. Please do all you can to achieve a peace settlement. We cannot resolve all the specific issues here, but I want a good and honorable agreement. To get that, you two will have to be moving together, and you should do everything you can to produce a success. ~~(C)~~

Secretary Christopher: It is very important that this meeting is taking place. It would be very desirable for the two Presidents to make the progress you mentioned regarding the Federation. The United States will have a role, through our arbitration and mediation, but the parties themselves must make the Federation work. ~~(C)~~

The President's time is limited and I know he wants to meet with the two presidents alone. ~~(C)~~

Richard Holbrooke: Let me make a few points in brief. We don't know how long the Dayton talks will last. We understand that President Tudjman will go back to Zagreb after a few days, but leaving a team led by Foreign Minister Granic with full authority to make decisions. Otherwise we are sticking with our original program. We will hopefully eliminate the sparring and daily contact with the press. Our delegation will be in daily contact with Secretary Christopher and Tony Lake. We are looking forward to working as a team. On to Dayton! ~~(C)~~

(At this point the President pulled Presidents Tudjman and Izetbegovic aside for a private conversation)

The President: I had a good conversation with President Yeltsin about Bosnia at Hyde Park. Yeltsin can help a little with the Serbs. Milosevic believes that there are too many independent contacts between the Russians and the Bosnian Serbs. We also want to show that if we achieve an agreement, Russia won't mess it up in a destructive way. Getting Russia more involved in the peace process could do a lot to smooth the way toward implementation. This is why Yeltsin had the idea that all three Balkan Presidents would go to Russia for a brief meeting -- little more than a photo opportunity -- just before the proximity talks in Dayton. ~~(C)~~

Now I know that you, President Tudjman, need to return to Zagreb because of your elections; and that you, President Izetbegovic had intended to stay in the United States up until the start of the Ohio talks. But if we proceeded as planned, with no meeting in Moscow before the Dayton talks, then it would be advisable to go to Moscow at some point before the first week of December. If we had an agreement at that time, it would not be a problem, it would largely be a formality. But if the proximity talks had adjourned without an agreement -- something which we hope will not happen -- a trip to Moscow could be more complicated. (C)

President Izetbegovic: Does President Yeltsin insist that we come before the Dayton talks? ~~(C)~~

The President: No. But he does have a political need for a visit at some point before the Duma elections. Let me add that I had a very good talk with Yeltsin. He has great respect for the two of you and believes that Russia has not done enough to pressure Milosevic. But he is also under pressure at home over the NATO issue and because of your recent gains on the battlefield. To help him strengthen his political base and make sure his opponents don't interfere with the peace process and with implementation, Yeltsin proposes to hold this meeting in Moscow. He is very supportive of the peace process. ~~(C)~~

Here is what we need. If the three Presidents could go to Moscow for just three hours before Dayton, the downside would be that the first pictures of the peace process would be coming from Russia. But nothing substantive could be discussed in such a short time and the Russians could not interfere with what happens afterwards. In short, we don't think anything bad could happen and the Russian people could see that Yeltsin is part of the peace process. In sum, I think it is safer to go now, even though I know it is hard on you, President Tudjman, and much harder on you, President Izetbegovic. For President Izetbegovic, we could give you a nice military plane that could take you to Moscow and then directly to Ohio. There could be a doctor, and the plane would not need to refuel or to make any other stops. Given the risks of doing it later, I think it would be best to get the Moscow visit over with. If it is too politically difficult for you, we can put it off until a later date. But if we do not go before the Duma elections -- that is, before the first week of December -- we could be inviting the Russians to screw up the peace process or the implementation of a settlement. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: I agree with you that it would be better to go to Moscow before Dayton. It could help influence the Serb side and encourage the Russians to be more constructive. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: Should we leave on the 30th, given the Croatian elections? ~~(C)~~

The President: We might need to start the Dayton talks on November 1 or 2. Richard Holbrooke has a lot of credibility and can explain a short delay. We would say that we wanted to have Yeltsin tell the Serbs to make peace. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: That is the only reason for the Moscow meeting. ~~(C)~~

The President: It is for that reason and also to ensure that the Russians do not get into our way on implementation. Let me repeat that Yeltsin was very honest with me. We have a good

relationship. But there are bad guys in Russia who want us to get into a fight with the Serbs. We don't want those forces to win the Duma elections on December 17. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: Yes, recently Zhirinovsky was in Belgrade. He was campaigning against peace and for the defense of the Orthodox world. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: When are the Duma elections? ~~(C)~~

The President: December 17. Doing the Moscow meeting after December 4 will be too late, because its political purposes would be too obvious. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: It is possible for me to go to Moscow on the 30th. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: The 31st would be better for me. ~~(C)~~

The President: This would mean that you would arrive in Dayton late on the 31st or November 1st. We will fly you there so that there are no stops for refueling. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman and President Izetbegovic: Okay. ~~(C)~~

The President: The faster we can do it, the better. ~~(C)~~

(The President then asked Richard Holbrooke to join the discussion)

Richard Holbrooke: We need to understand that this meeting in Moscow is not a Contact Group meeting. The U.S. representative will be Ambassador Pickering. Any other representation would turn it into a negotiation session. Secondly, there will be no joint declaration or joint statement. The Russians may make a unilateral statement of 2 or 3 sentences, but this would not be subject to any protracted negotiations. ~~(C)~~

The President: We don't need a declaration because the purpose of the meeting is to enable Yeltsin to send a signal to the Serbs and for Russia to be seen to be involved in the process. ~~(C)~~

Richard Holbrooke: The Moscow meeting will significantly improve Russian support both for the Dayton talks and for the implementation force. The only thing is how to set things in motion. I will call Milosevic. If he says no, then it's a new ball game. If he says yes, then we will proceed with a Moscow meeting on October 31. ~~(C)~~

-- End of Conversation --

Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

This is not a presidential record. This is used as an administrative marker by the William J. Clinton Presidential Library Staff.

Documents from this Mandatory Declassification Review were released in full.
